ENTREPRENEUR GUIDE TO PERSONAL GROWTH

Satiate your need for adventure while building a bold life rich with success

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters to Entrepreneurs

Personal growth isn't the one-size-fits-all affair that some self-help books would have readers believe. For Entrepreneurs, personal growth is always about balancing spontaneity with responsibility, independence with intimacy, and desire for novelty with an appreciation for things as they are. The goal is never for Entrepreneurs to change essential characteristics, but rather for them to acquire a greater array of tools that allow them to weigh their impulses against their longer-term goals. Personal growth is always about defying the boundaries of one's comfort zone while simultaneously not losing one's true self.

In these pages, we'll discuss how the first step for Entrepreneurs on the road to personal growth is to develop self-awareness – in other words, assessing themselves and their behaviors. Along the way, Entrepreneurs will ask themselves what they want from life, both now and in the future. This thinking need not box them into plans that are rigid, uncomfortable, or (heaven forbid!) boring. Instead, considering the future can open up new and more fulfilling possibilities. The final step of growth involves replacing unhelpful behaviors with new behaviors that bring Entrepreneurs closer to what they want most in life.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Motivation and Development

Entrepreneurs can consider personal growth in three closely related but distinct areas that relate to internally developing self-regard:

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much Entrepreneurs like themselves. Accepting both their flaws and strengths creates a base of internal appreciation that enables change motivated by desire instead of shame.
- **Self-respect** speaks to their sense of worth. People with this personality type value rational logic, and when they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are follows.
- **Self-confidence** is the energy source that moves Entrepreneurs forward in life. When belief in their abilities is confirmed using their skills, Entrepreneurs are driven to make steady progress.

If these three core aspects are properly balanced, they can promote a successful and fulfilling life. Should elements become unbalanced, however, they become a source of overwhelming difficulty. For example, when Entrepreneurs feel a lack of self-confidence, they might behave in certain ways to boost their confidence. Problems arise, however, when they overcompensate to do so and consequently throw their lives out of balance.

Moving Forward

In the following sections, we'll first examine Entrepreneurs' characteristics in their ideal, balanced, and fully developed form. Using these motivational aspects in balanced ways helps Entrepreneurs lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives.

Next, we'll describe the tendencies that emerge if these aspects become unbalanced. These represent departures from healthy, productive motivational strategies and explain adverse effects Entrepreneurs experience when they disconnect from their true selves.

Finally, we'll discuss what can be done to improve balance in each of the motivational aspects.

Self-Esteem

It's common for rational people to struggle to reconcile their emotions with their intellect, which Entrepreneurs often apply to their mastery of skills. Those who maintain harmony between the two create strong foundations in their lives that bring stability and satisfaction. The conflict between their drive and the rest of their lives can inhibit happiness and dry up inspiration, while a sense that they've balanced the two allows good things to happen. Entrepreneurs must decide how to satisfy their self-esteem fueled drive while appreciating the other parts of their lives.

Balanced Self-Esteem

For Entrepreneurs, a sense of competence and mastery enhances their sense of self-esteem. In endeavors that matter to them, these individuals aim to constantly hone their skills, innovate, and improve. Unwilling to settle for the status quo, they feel driven to experiment thanks to their natural curiosity, their extraordinary perception, and their creative edge. This willingness to try new things and push past old limits naturally leads to mastery of a skill or a situation.

Entrepreneurs always want to improve, but they also appreciate how far they've come. Although they love "impossible" challenges, they accept that not every experiment can work out. They recognize their strengths and their weaknesses, and neither self-adulation nor self-criticism hinders their doing a good job.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

When their self-esteem is unbalanced, Entrepreneurs are likely to believe that dominating their field can restore their self-worth. They may sacrifice important aspects of their lives – such as their relationships – in pursuit of mastery. Alas, pursuing perfection is never-ending, and external accomplishments aren't a stable foundation for self-esteem.

When Entrepreneurs focus almost exclusively on their area of expertise, it might delight their employers, teachers, or coaches. This intense, narrow focus can cause collateral damage in other areas, however.

Sometimes Entrepreneurs must choose between pursuing their goals and caring for others' needs. When this happens, some choose their goals over their relationships.

It's important to note that Entrepreneurs don't do this because they dislike people. However, because they don't want to be distracted from their work during these times, Entrepreneurs can sideline other people's needs, whether it means canceling a call with a friend who's having a hard time or not taking the kids to soccer practice. In extreme cases, Entrepreneurs might achieve mastery but alienate their spouses, friends, and family.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

When the quest for mastery becomes an obsession, Entrepreneurs must step back and see the bigger picture – specifically, what areas of their lives they're neglecting. To do so, they can look to their calendars for clues on how they spend their time. Specifically, Entrepreneurs should note how much time they devote per week to each of these areas: work or school, family, friends, self-care, sleep, hobbies, and downtime.

Once they see this breakdown, Entrepreneurs can ask themselves whether the way they spend their time reflects their values. Are they shortchanging their health or their relationships? How can they redistribute their time and attention to move toward an ideal schedule?

As they change their lives, Entrepreneurs can take heart by reminding themselves that self-esteem built on a single area of accomplishment isn't sustainable in the long run. By focusing on competence and growth rather than perfection, Entrepreneurs can leave room in their lives for the other things that matter.

Maintaining the Right Focus

Often captured by both widespread distraction and hyperfocus to the exclusion of much of what's important in life, Entrepreneurs can struggle to find a balance between school, work, relationships, recreation, and other personal goals. A "come what may" sense of excited opportunism

can define their pursuits, clouding their long-term planning. A success-oriented type, Entrepreneurs may find that issues with focus can prevent them from manifesting their achievements, detracting from their self-esteem.

Whether spread too thin or drawn overmuch to a specific activity, Entrepreneurs can find themselves troubled in important life areas. It can help them to define their goals, tone down *unnecessary* distractions from those goals, and then use all their energy and drive to achieve what's important to them rather than what's merely available to them.

Step 1: Define your goals.

Indecision can be a major stumbling block on the road of life. The inability to complete a goal in a timely fashion often stems from the vagueness of markers, from the lack of specific objectives required for the culmination of our dreams. The sooner you know the path that you want to be on, the sooner you can start walking on it, closer and closer to the reward that you seek. Although there is nothing wrong with exploring more than one avenue of opportunity, you may find the quickest route to success by narrowing your aims to the people and ideas that are truly important to you.

1. Write down your long-term goals. These can be anything from finishing a degree to deepening a relationship with someone important. Don't concern yourself with practicality or likelihood. Some of the goals that you list can be eliminated or revised later, but it's important not to restrict yourself prematurely.

2. Choose one long-term goal, and begin to segment it into an "if/then" statement: If the goal in question is to be completed, then what must be done to see it to fruition? Again, resist the temptation to cross off any goals from your list at this point.

3. Create an "if/then" statement for the rest of your long-term goals, one at a time.

4. After you have completed the entire list, begin to pare it down to no more than three goals and statements. If you have more than three long-term goals, paring down your list is necessary. You can always change your mind later, but a focused pursuit demands a narrow range of objectives.

Step 2: Remove distractions.

Even after restricting yourself and being more discerning about your goals, the urge to constantly seek new fires to fight can remain strong. Although your schedule should ideally be flexible enough to accommodate a true emergency, you may sometimes need to ignore smaller crises (or opportunities) to remain on track toward your larger goals. By removing more trivial distractions, you free up your focus for more important matters.

1. Set a limit to your daily time spent on social media, aiming to reduce your consumption by about 50%. For many, social media has become an unprecedented source of distracting information. With countless friends and acquaintances routinely laid bare, it can sometimes be almost as difficult to look away as if the person were screaming and waving outside your window. As such, it might be helpful to reduce your social media habit, if not get rid of it completely.

2. Make a list of your chores and obligations for the day or week. When your tasks are in black and white, they often seem much more doable. Every day, look for at least one chore or obligation that you can get rid of, particularly habits that have outgrown their usefulness. If you discover that you don't miss it, you might realize that you can better use the time.

Step 3: Practice single-tasking.

If multitasking has become your default mode of operation, doing only one thing at a time can strangely seem like a formidable challenge. Even though you may believe that you save time by multitasking, single-tasking is typically the more productive approach.

1. Practice letting go... of your smartphone. Turn it off for significant periods throughout the week. Smartphone use while driving has produced perhaps the most glaring consequences of multitasking with a mobile device. But no matter when your attention is divided, it's by definition distracted.

Start small if you must. Turn it off only when you're in the car or while drinking your coffee. Build the length and frequency of your smartphone timeouts until you feel noticeably less attached and more focused.

1. **Make food the centerpiece of your meals, not an afterthought.**

   Instead of choking down a granola bar during a morning commute, wake up a few minutes early to have breakfast in the comfort of your kitchen or dining room. Perhaps, rather than eating dinner by the television screen light, eat it by candlelight instead.

2. **Make room for one-on-one time.**

   If someone is important to you, show them. One-on-one time and dedicated attention without the distraction of multitasking (see the smartphone suggestion above) is one of the best ways to show others that you care.

3. **Finish things.**

   Before starting a new book, television series, or project, try revisiting one you'd previously abandoned for no obvious reason.

   Are there any promises you've made that you haven't kept? (It happens to us all.) Here's an opportunity to focus, finish, and stay true to your words.

   Learn to break goals down into smaller steps. See Step One above. If something feels overwhelming and too big, it can be hard to find the important steps needed to complete it as you move through a project. Learning to make efforts bite sized helps you learn to focus and to think in terms of finishing the smaller task in service of the larger project that you will finish later down the road.

4. **Adopt a "less is more" mantra.**

   Consider a more minimalistic attitude so that there is less clutter in your life pulling you away from the important things that you need to be focusing on.

   Find out how many ways you can simplify your time, your work, your finances, your obligations, your relationships, and so on.

By reducing distractions and resisting the temptation to multitask, you can free your mind of clutter and chaos, allowing yourself to focus on not only small tasks but also your long-term goals. It can be exciting to have a full plate to deal with every day and to have many things to think

about. But when possible, the responsible route will be to prioritize and focus for clarity and effectiveness.

Self-Respect

For Entrepreneurs, self-respect comes from their ability to think on their feet and solve problems on almost an improvisational level. Their self-respect doesn't involve deep deliberation. They prefer the action encompassed in assessing a situation and providing a hands-on solution. It doesn't matter which discipline they master – the dynamic is the same. They like to think of themselves as individuals who can manipulate the different parts of their specialties to provide results.

Balanced Self-Respect

Predictability and stability bring no sense of fulfillment to Entrepreneurs. Instead, these individuals value themselves most when they see themselves as flexible and able to deal skillfully with the unexpected. People with this personality type assess themselves by how well they solve problems. In striving for self-respect, Entrepreneurs hone and exercise their skill at handling sudden predicaments.

While most personality types want stability, Entrepreneurs find no satisfaction in metaphorical "solid ground." They want to navigate choppy waters, taking pride in their ability to steer through even the toughest storms. Entrepreneurs' ability to think on their feet is the one trait they value most about themselves. When they're able to tackle time-critical situations, people with this personality type recognize the gifts and strengths that they bring to the world.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

To enhance their self-respect, some Entrepreneurs may take on needless risks, seeking out crises, emergencies, or even dangerous circumstances to prove their value. The people in their lives – including partners, friends, and coworkers – are often alarmed by this unbalanced desire to seek out problems and precarious situations. They may see

these Entrepreneurs as careless, unstable, undependable, or even dangerous.

Entrepreneurs with such an unbalanced approach tend to tune out other people's guidance – even advice from those they trust – when they find themselves "on a mission." Think of Don Draper on the television series *Mad Men* and the unpopular, bold risks he took to solve problems at his ad agency. These maneuvers are generally single-minded, ignoring other people's needs, feelings, and preferences. Entrepreneurs whose self-respect is fueled by adrenaline and risk may inadvertently hurt or push away the people they love.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

To rebalance their self-respect, Entrepreneurs can write out a list of things they like about themselves. This should include several other traits besides their ability to solve problems on the fly. Do they appreciate their curiosity? The way they introduce friends and loved ones to exciting new experiences? Their ability to find joy in travel, exploration, or stimulating conversation?

Entrepreneurs have *many* strengths. By learning to appreciate themselves for everything they are, they won't need to seek precarious circumstances – or ignore other people's needs – to feel genuine self-respect.

The Resilient Entrepreneur

We've all heard clichés like, "It's not how many times you fall down but how many times you get up that matters." Being resilient enough to keep going even after failure and defeat is often regarded as a sign of character. It can easily be assumed that persistent self-recovery and thriving despite defeats are reasons to respect oneself. The ability to take a chance, fail, and then bounce back may hold the key to self-respect for many Entrepreneurs.

Entrepreneurs often go boldly into the unknown and take enormous risks. Some would argue that there is less of a chance of great success apart from taking great risks. When a person has this kind of impulsive

bravery, they had better be able to pick themselves up if the worst happens. When they look in the mirror, those resilient Entrepreneurs are likely to be happier with what they see than those who aren't able to restore themselves so easily after a self-created catastrophe. For the latter, we offer the following exercise for building a resilient life:

Step 1: Build a support system.

This step is especially important. Having a safety net of people goes a long way toward creating resilience. Knowing that you have people who love you – no matter how badly you fail – can keep you upright and strong even when the going gets tough. This should not be so hard for Entrepreneurs. They are social creatures, but their network may not be intentionally structured. It's great to have a lot of friends, but it's even better if some of those friends have what it takes to be there when you need them.

What does support have to do with resilience? It's easier to put things back together again if you have a crew standing by who are willing and able to help. Emotional support is one of the biggest factors in recovering from a loss. A person can be resilient on their own, but they will likely find it much harder than someone with help.

1. Think about what kind of support you want or need. Take a few minutes to figure out who you'd like on your support team.
    a. Do you want a mentor with experience or a peer going through the same challenges?
    b. Who would you want as a member of your team? What qualities would those people have?
    c. Ask yourself what kind of support you need from your support team.
    d. How often do you want to have contact: daily, weekly, or less often?
    e. What are your shared goals with this team?
    f. List the resources available to you right now. You likely have many more resources available to you than you realize.

g. Who are your current friends?

h. What friends from the past might you reach out to?

i. Who have you offered support to?

j. Are you a member of a social group or other organization?

k. Do you have a colleague at work or a neighbor you could ask for support?

2. Write a list of places or resources that might provide you with access to a support network. All these resources can help you meet other people with common interests, leading to friendship and mutual support.

   a. Do you want to join a gym?

   b. Could you become a member of a networking group or service organization?

   c. Might you ask your alma mater to match you with a mentor in your field?

   d. Can you take a course or seminar?

Step 2: Reframe your thoughts.

Reframing is essential to coping with bad situations. It's less about "finding the silver lining" and more about acknowledging that your problems may not be as bad as you believe them to be. On top of that, once you start looking at your difficulties in different ways, your worldview and faulty assumptions have a chance to shift, and you gain perspectives and learn life lessons. As a result, these problems may have less impact in the future.

The following steps can help you explore your problems from different angles:

1. Write down a problem that you have.

2. Create a second column and jot a few beliefs and feelings that you have about your problems.

3. In a third column, create a list of alternative beliefs about your problems and explore other ways of feeling about them. Get creative. How might you react to the three differently? What positive lessons or insights can you can gain from these problems?

4. Try it again with another problem.

Example:

Column one: I am broke and there is still a week and a half until payday.

Column two: I am horrible with money. I will always be living paycheck-to-paycheck. I don't know how I will survive until the end of the month. I make enough money, and this shouldn't be happening. I can't even afford to buy groceries. My partner will be so angry because they have their own financial obligation taking all of their income this month.

Column three: What an adventure. There's no need to see the worst here. I'm not inherently bad with money. I'm work in progress and learning more every day. There are plenty of ingredients in the pantry. I bet I can put together all kinds of interesting dishes. This could be fun and different. I can now look back on how we spent my income this month, and the idea of carefully budgeting and spending is no longer abstract. Now, I can look into the future and plan more realistically. And my partner and I have had a need to talk about money and create a financial plan for a long time, and we keep putting it off. It's going to be hard *not* to talk about it this month. We'll finally get that messy piece of business out of the way.

Step 3. Create a better routine.

Creating a routine and developing structure in life have been shown to help people who feel lost. Having something you do every day or every week gives you something to look forward to, and actively pursuing a goal can help you feel more accomplished. Accomplishment is one of the key building blocks of routine in that it not only builds better resilience but also overall confidence.

1. Write down your current routines.

2. If your schedule seems somewhat erratic, make it more structured by writing the order in which you will go about your day.

   For example: Wake up at the same time on workdays, get ready in the same order, grab a coffee from the same place instead of wherever, and check your email at designated times.

   Brainstorm several ways to add something enjoyable or beneficial to your daily or weekly routine. Ideally, these activities will involve others who can hold you accountable and be potential friends and supporters in the future.

   For example: Sign up for a weekly painting class, commit to walking with a coworker for 15 minutes during lunch, or volunteer to help the food bank every Tuesday.

3. Pick your favorite idea and pursue it. Don't delay – enroll, sign up, show up, and jump in!

4. Stick to your routine no matter what. Remember, you may find individuals who may become potential friends and supporters in the future.

After a month or two, reflect on how you've felt since you started building some support around yourself, reframing the way you look at your problems, and enhancing your routine. Chances are good that you will feel as if you have planted the seeds to grow more hopeful and resilient.

Consider what other resources or methods you could use when you need to get past failures or difficulties. Remember, the better you can restore yourself at these times, the more likely you will feel good about who you are and what you do.

Self-Confidence

Many credit German writer and statesman Goethe with saying, "Boldness has genius, power, and magic in it. Begin it now." This quote is music to the ears of Entrepreneurs. A sense of boldness gives them the confidence and energy they need to move forward in life.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Entrepreneurs tend to have little regard for traditional standards or rules, which are too confining for their creative imaginations. Spontaneous experiments and explorations energize people with this personality type, who always want to find the "next new thing." Where other people dread change, Entrepreneurs typically embrace it.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

We admire boldness in our culture, and our typical hero is likely to be bold and act in bigger-than-life ways. Entrepreneurs can take this too far, making unbalanced, audacious, and dramatic decisions whether or not the situation calls for them. These Entrepreneurs may rashly disregard plans, agreements, or even good sense. Every now and then this recklessness may pay off, inflating their self-esteem, but at other times the results are disastrous.

When Entrepreneurs make unfounded decisions that affect other people, they risk disconnecting themselves from their colleagues, their social network, and their loved ones. If they don't balance their actions with common sense and consideration of other people's needs, then the people around them may just shake their heads at what they only see as erratic behavior.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Mission statements have become a staple for goal setting and self-improvement – for a good reason. These statements help people and organizations identify what matters to them and how they can act in alignment with these values. Entrepreneurs might not love long-term

planning, but mission statements can help them recognize and explore the possibilities available to them – something that they find intensely gratifying. In addition, when they recognize their core values, they're less likely to sacrifice them for adrenaline highs, erratic decisions, or confidence boosts.

To identify their values and priorities, Entrepreneurs should ask themselves these questions:

- "If I had one day left to live, what would I do?"
- "If I had one year left to live, what would I do?"
- "If I had unlimited financial resources, how would I use them to make a difference in the world?"
- "What would an ideal romantic relationship look like to me? How about an ideal social life? An ideal family life?"

Once they've answered these questions, they can organize their insights into personal mission statements which can serve as types of treasure maps in their pursuit of the lives they want.

Moderating Self-Confidence Using Rational Thinking for Risk Reduction

It may seem unnecessary to discuss using rational thinking to override emotion with a Thinking type like an Entrepreneur. That said, Entrepreneurs tend to be among the most optimistic of all the personality types and are likely not as stressed out in the face of difficulties as others. But that leads to another rationality problem. Being too optimistic can lead to overconfidence, leading to serious life errors, and enough of those can erode the confidence of even the most upbeat individual.

One way to deal with excessive optimism or overconfidence is by subjecting it to the ABCDE Model. The ABCDE Model, originally developed by Albert Ellis as a component of his Rational Emotive Behavior Therapy (REBT), is the basis of this exercise. This exercise aims to confront faulty and harmful ways of thinking and replace them with more effective rational beliefs and thoughts. More typically we think of this REBT as a means of dealing with negative emotions that come from negative thought patterns and which lead to states like anxiety or

depression, but it's just as useful a technique when automatic thoughts are too positive.

For Entrepreneurs, that new and exciting possibility might be the thing that they want to hit the pause button on and subject to this exercise. In novel situations, excitement can overwhelm Entrepreneurs' normally rational thought processes, leading to rash, illogical behaviors. Entrepreneurs may develop overly optimistic beliefs about a situation if they aren't aware that their emotions are hijacking their mental capacities.

This exercise can help you utilize your rational thinking skills to moderate your emotional reactions during either stressful or exciting situations. Here's a breakdown of the process:

Step 1: Pinpoint an **Activating** event.

1. This event causes irrational thinking and results in inappropriate or negative behavioral consequences.
2. Write down an event that took place recently that resulted in negative consequences or behavior.
    a. *Example: This is exciting. I've never seen anything like that before. I think I'll invest.*

Step 2: List your **Beliefs**.

1. Irrational or harmful beliefs are generally subconscious and often nearly undetectable. They can be difficult to identify, especially in the heat of the moment.
2. Write down your beliefs about the incident you described in Step 1.
    a. *Example: No risk, no gain. And I need to get in on this novel discovery before everyone else does.*

Step 3: Specify the **Consequences**.

1. Emotional consequences result from the harmful or irrational beliefs in Step 2. These consequences can range from reckless behaviors to emotional outbursts.

2. Now, write down the consequences of your irrational beliefs.
    a. *Example: I could risk a lot only to discover that this endeavor fails under the test of time. I could lose a lot and undermine my natural confidence.*

Step 4: **Dispute** your own views.

1. Change begins with disputing or challenging irrational beliefs. At first, disputing beliefs is a reflective process, but as time goes on, this step can take place immediately after the activating event.
2. Write down a dispute of your previously-held beliefs in Step 2. How have you shifted the way that you view the event? What would be a more productive or positive way of thinking about the event? This part requires some reflection and adjustment of your beliefs.
    a. *Example: Just because something is new and seems exciting doesn't mean that it's exempt from the usual rigors of testing and exploration. My excitement isn't the final arbiter of what is good and right.*

Step 5: Recognizing the **Effects** of changed thoughts.

1. Once you've disputed your irrational thoughts, you can replace them with effective beliefs which lead to more adaptive, beneficial behaviors.
2. Think about how changing your beliefs about the activating event in Step 1 could've resulted in a more positive outcome.
    a. *Example: I can still be optimistic and excited without taking excessive risks. If it's a good endeavor, then it should be able to withstand tests of time and more investigation.*

Like it or not, most people have to deal with irrational thoughts and fears. It's part of the price of being human. Sometimes they are harmless thoughts, but in many cases they can lead to repeated difficulties that erode a person's self-confidence. Now you have a technique to challenge any thoughts that are suspect or hinder your success by promoting actions that amount to unnecessary risks or troublesome impulsivity. Slowing down and using the ABCDE method can help sort out the exciting and sound initiatives from the exciting but flawed direction.

Pursuing Personal Growth

Entrepreneurs embody a curious paradox. Gregarious and charismatic, they draw people to them. At parties, people flock around them, trying to edge in on their conversations – which are, more likely than not, fascinating. Romantic partners may fall head over heels for Entrepreneurs, attracted to their adventurous, passionate spirits. These influences can come with some pitfalls, however. Although Entrepreneurs are logical and utilitarian, they must balance their persuasive powers with consideration of others' feelings.

Another area where Entrepreneurs may struggle is planning and consistency. Spontaneous to the point of thrill seeking, these individuals like to live in the moment and leave their options open. This mindset can create problems, however, preventing them from reaching their full potential in their careers, their relationships, and their daily lives.

Let's explore these areas further and consider how Entrepreneurs can make use of their strengths while counterbalancing their weaknesses.

Interpersonal Effectiveness

Balanced Interpersonal Effectiveness

Outsiders may think that Entrepreneurs are very empathic and sensitive. In reality, they're using their observation and improvisation skills, instinctively knowing how they should react to what other people say or do. This usually leads to their becoming quite popular in many professional and personal circles.

Entrepreneurs can leverage their interpersonal strengths in balanced ways and approach all their relationships – whether they're intimate relationships or business partnerships – with integrity. By cultivating balanced awareness of other people's needs, feelings, and desires, Entrepreneurs can pursue their own interests without steamrolling over the people in their lives.

Unbalanced Interpersonal Effectiveness

If they wish, Entrepreneurs can exploit other people's weaknesses, manipulating or convincing them to do things that go against their best

interests. They're likely to have the potential to become outstanding innovators or brilliant con artists. It's up to them to decide where to draw the line.

Used to getting what they want through subtle manipulation, some Entrepreneurs may exploit people, casting aside any scruples or consideration of others. Deeply utilitarian at heart, these individuals worry little about external rules or guidelines. They may take this an unbalanced step further, advancing their own self-interest through selfish or even antisocial activities.

These manipulations can take on subtler manifestations. Entrepreneurs have a sensation-seeking personality, and they cherish variety and unpredictability. They may engineer dramas in unbalanced ways, convincing other people to perform inadvisable acts just for the excitement. For example, they might persuade friends to commit misdemeanors or colleagues to say something inflammatory to their bosses. When acting in an unbalanced manner, Entrepreneurs have only a superficial appreciation or awareness of other's feelings, so they have few qualms about using people for their benefit.

Rebalancing Interpersonal Effectiveness

Entrepreneurs can honor their integrity and deepen their relationships by developing their emotional intelligence. This doesn't come easily to them, even though their Extraversion and their observational skills help them enjoy sociable, well connected lives. Beneath the surface, Entrepreneurs may have significant difficulties expressing how they feel and recognizing other people's emotions – something that proves limiting in their close relationships. If such skills are left underdeveloped, their friends and partners are likely to feel as if something is missing.

Because Entrepreneurs can infer so much about people through their interactions, it might not occur to them that the simplest way to discover how someone feels is to ask. With reflection, Entrepreneurs might realize that they're viewing the people in their lives as pawns to be influenced or managed. In these situations, these individuals would do well to ask these questions:

- "What are you feeling or thinking right now?"
- "What do you need from me?"
- "How can we proceed in a way that is good for both of us?"

Once Entrepreneurs hear the answers to these questions, they can use the resulting insights to channel their interpersonal abilities in positive directions, striving toward mutual benefit rather than personal gain.

Building Empathy Skills

The way to ensure that our overtures to others are not manipulative or harmful is to get a sense and appreciation for the other person's feelings and experiences. That kind of connection takes building one's empathy skills.

The first step to empathy is connecting with another's experience on a personal level. However, the Entrepreneurs' primary instincts will likely drive them to action rather than simply sharing the experience. Empathy is not necessarily about doing something to help or to fix a problem. Suppose the listener goes immediately to a remedy without fully hearing the concerns of the person that they're trying to relate to. In that case, it will feel like the listener hasn't heard them or doesn't care about their emotional distress.

Emotional intelligence has a lot to do with learning to empathize. Building our skills in really listening and trying to step momentarily into another person's experience and emotional space is essential to good interpersonal relationships. Try the steps below to strengthen your ability to empathize.

1. Learn to monitor the other person's body language and facial expressions when intense subjects arise. That is often the first gateway to pass through when trying to empathize. Words aren't always readily available to some.
    a. Does the person sharing make eye contact, and are they engaged with you in the moment?
    b. Does the speaker appear:
        i. Closed off or open?

   ii. Relaxed or rigid?

   iii. Uncomfortable and fidgety?

   c. Does their body language tell you that you are bringing relief or frustration?

   d. Paying attention and learning to trust the message that the other person's body telegraphs can provide an early warning system that the situation needs a different response.

2. Learn to listen actively. Here are a few starter techniques:

   a. Keep your own body language open and welcoming.

   b. Nod appropriately. (Excessive nodding can come across as anxious or impatient. A casual or relaxed nod that punctuates your understanding of an idea can be reassuring and encourages the speaker to continue.)

   c. Paraphrase back what you hear from the other person. Mirror in your own words, but go for accuracy. Don't muddy their sentiment with your own thoughts. There will be time for your input later.

3. Ask more questions than you make statements. Make sure your inquiry is open to the other person's information, whatever that may be. Avoid any judgment when you ask for clarification. (An accusing tone can easily slip in.) If you feel like you are holding court, you probably are. Behave less like a member of an inquisition and be more compassionately curious than insistent on gathering facts.

4. Make it a point to ask the person that you're empathizing with about their feelings. Remember the cliché: "Nobody cares what you know until they know that you care." Inquiring about feelings takes things to a more compassionate level than coldly asking about hard facts.

5. Think of periods of silence as a strategy and welcome them. Make a quiet space for empathy. When the hard facts take a rest, emotions, separated from the tyranny of the objective, have more room to play. Explore the idea of just "being." Sitting quietly with someone in emotional pain is sometimes a more powerful salve than all the

comforting words one can muster in the middle of an upsetting situation.

6. Don't offer a solution unless it is asked for or unless you first ask if it is wanted. This is crucial because people often need to tell their story and know that someone cares. They are not sharing to receive feedback. If the person should want feedback, allow them to reject anything that you suggest without feeling bad or making them feel bad for the position that they hold on your suggestion. You are not being rejected. Your solution is. It's sometimes hard for people, especially Thinking types like Entrepreneurs, to separate the two things.
7. **Bonus tip:** Role-play all the above with someone that you trust to be honest with you. It might feel a bit silly, but practice indeed makes perfect.

So, a core skill to building an effective interpersonal style is to recognize that people aren't just a bundle of facts and behaviors. Even the person who leans most heavily on the Thinking trait still feels on a profound level – whether they admit it or not.

Rational understanding is important, but it might be argued that one's true humanity is found in the ability to respond emotionally to the world and the people around them. When someone allows you to skillfully touch their inner emotional life, they are letting you touch their humanity. There may be no greater way to honor you than to allow you into this intimate part of their lives. Make sure to appreciate these human moments.

Planning

Balanced Planning

Entrepreneurs, with their nerves of steel, epitomize grace under pressure and can often save themselves through their highly developed observational skills and willingness to do everything and anything to achieve their goals. Some of their favorite memories may involve close scrapes or unexpected adventures.

However, Entrepreneurs at their best recognize that true freedom requires planning – whether this means setting up a retirement account, seeing the doctor for a physical, or getting routine maintenance for a car. The adventures they crave rarely entail going broke, getting sick, or waiting on the side of the road for a tow truck. By doing enough planning to get by, Entrepreneurs leave room in their lives for the experiences that matter to them.

Unbalanced Planning

Alas, even Entrepreneurs sometimes run out of luck. Those who approach their lives in an unbalanced manner may be spontaneous to the point of carelessness, unwilling to make or stick to plans. It's true that optimism enables these types to notice and take advantage of various opportunities, but they may take this too far. By prioritizing quick action over research or analysis, they may make unbalanced snap decisions and hope for the best.

In their professional lives, this leaves Entrepreneurs vulnerable to critics who might emphasize mistakes they've made or matters they have left unattended. In their unbalanced private lives, Entrepreneurs may neglect longer-term endeavors such as financial planning, home maintenance, or even managing their health.

Rebalancing Planning

Let's face it: Entrepreneurs aren't likely to stick to complicated action plans or spend hours each day maintaining their calendars. Instead, they can incorporate planning into their lives by recruiting friends, colleagues, and professionals with expertise in such relevant areas. For example, Entrepreneurs might ask meticulous coworkers to collaborate on projects, hire accountants or financial planners to ensure that they manage their finances, or ask savvy friends to help them identify what improvements they must make to their homes. By getting assistance with planning, Entrepreneurs can save time and energy to focus on their true strengths.

Creating a Vision and Setting Goals

Entrepreneurs who want to feel a sense of earned pride in their lives will likely also start by having a sense that they have a vision for their future. A sense of self-respect will come when they feel that they have met the goals that help them accomplish their larger vision. As an Entrepreneur, one way to do that is to define your goals and habitually maintain them as a clear target in your life.

To determine the life that you could live contentedly, it's often helpful to visualize what you want. Look at your complete life and determine how you want it to look in specific terms. Entrepreneurs tend to let unrealistic expectations or unbridled excitement about their novel ideas dictate the direction of their lives – but holding firm to a preestablished endgame can help them to regain control. Determining their ideal life is the most effective way to develop and secure those boundaries.

More than likely, you will have multiple areas in your life where you'd like to imagine your best possible outcomes, but pick just two or three for this exercise. You can always go through this process and add other areas that you would like to improve at another time in the future.

1. Start by selecting the specific area that you want to focus on. It could be a relationship, a job, your education, or any area of your life, big or small.
2. Then, in the most vivid detail possible, write what you desire for that specific situation on a piece of paper. Plan on spending at least 15 to 20 minutes on this portion of the activity.
3. Reread this detailed description once daily as part of your routine. Take the time to close your eyes and visualize this exact scenario in your mind like a movie on a screen.
4. Repeat these steps for other areas of your life that you want to design for your ideal life.

Example: If you are looking at switching careers, you would want to write in detail exactly what kind of career you would like: Imagine your daily routine and where you want to work (in an office, from home, in your current city, overseas, etc.), think about what kind of hours you want to work, envision what kind of boss and coworkers you want to

have. If working from a different location, visualize your office, the view from your window – consider anything that matters to you, down to the smallest details. Creating a physical visualization of this can be helpful by drawing it, creating an online "mood board," or even cutting pictures out of magazines and creating a collage – anything that can more fully bring the vision to life!

Making Good Use of Entrepreneur Traits

Entrepreneurs have many gifts and talents, particularly their spontaneity and adaptability. They may find themselves with too much of a good thing, however. Let's investigate how Entrepreneurs can use their strengths – and avoid being used by them.

Spontaneity

Balanced Spontaneity

Entrepreneurs' most impressive trait is their ability to "think on their feet" – people with this personality type can make snap decisions, staying cool in stressful situations. They're excellent troubleshooters, especially where there's a need to act quickly and ignore the established procedures. Entrepreneurs are fiercely utilitarian, willing to do what it takes to get the job done, even if it means breaking with existing traditions or dismissing people who disapprove of their sometimes renegade actions.

If the circumstances are right, people with this personality type shouldn't be reluctant to embrace their spontaneity, which enables them to notice and seize opportunities that other personality types might miss. Entrepreneurs are well equipped to make the most of difficult situations, dealing with unexpected challenges and succeeding with scarce resources. This enables them to excel in unfavorable environments, knowing exactly how far the limits can be pushed, what tactics can be pursued, and which resources can be utilized.

Unbalanced Spontaneity

In their younger years, Entrepreneurs' spontaneity may have been discouraged by authority figures who told them to be methodical, honor tradition, and follow well-established paths. This is most likely to occur in such highly structured environments as schools or public institutions. Young Entrepreneurs may often feel as if their strengths are undervalued and may even repress their spontaneity and desire for excitement.

When Entrepreneurs discover the value of their spontaneity, they may go overboard and take it to the extreme, refusing to commit to a course

of action even when necessary. They may move on from jobs and abandon half-finished projects in an unbalanced manner whenever fresh challenges present themselves. This roving approach can even extend to their personal lives, with Entrepreneurs refusing to assure their loved ones of their constancy. To justify this unbalanced lack of commitment, they might argue that life is unpredictable, and they want to live in the moment.

This unbalanced attitude fails to take other people's needs into account. Romantic partners, family members, and even friends may pull away or become hurt if they feel they can't depend on Entrepreneurs to be there for them. Unless these types recognize the validity of other people's needs – including reassurance, devotion, and loyalty – they won't be able to enjoy strong, lasting relationships.

Rebalancing Spontaneity

Flexibility and adaptability are among Entrepreneurs' greatest strengths, and people with this personality type should seek careers, academic paths, and hobbies that leverage their abilities in these areas. When their personal lives are balanced, however, Entrepreneurs pay attention to other people's needs and expectations, including the need for commitment when appropriate.

To rebalance their spontaneity with demonstrations of loyalty to the people who matter, Entrepreneurs can make a list of their most important relationships, including friends, family members, and romantic partners. With this list in mind, they can use their flexibility to their advantage, looking for spontaneous ways to demonstrate affection, care, and support for these people. For example, they might take their partners on spur-of-the-moment weekend trips, swing by to visit friends with takeout from a new restaurant, or pull off the road and pick wildflowers for their children. These unexpected gestures can reassure people of Entrepreneurs' care and support.

Playing the Devil's Advocate

Entrepreneurs are certainly thoughtful enough regarding practical details, but they also tend to approach things quickly and too

optimistically without considering some of the negatives that are part of the big picture. This spontaneous mindset can lead to impulsivity that fixes today's problems without a good sense of how such actions affect tomorrow. This lack of foresight can become problematic for this risk-taking personality type, ultimately affecting their ability to do what they want in life.

So, it may be important to find some way to moderate your enthusiastic adoption of that which is novel and interesting. Perhaps finding processes to temper your admirable spontaneity and optimism with more practical information could be important to maintaining a better self-image and a sense of growth.

Listening with an open mind can be a valuable part of this process. It helps you to slow down when you need to slow down. But remember: Just as you have your self-interested motives for holding on to a particular viewpoint, so do others have their agendas, clouding their objectivity and rendering their conclusions suspect. So whether the opinion is your own or someone else's, it may be helpful for Entrepreneurs to "play devil's advocate" by providing alternate views to your own opinions or the opinions of others.

You can test and challenge your ideas or the ideas of others by following these simple steps:

Step 1: Try trivial contrarianism.

Playing devil's advocate may be a helpful tool for better understanding the weaknesses in your most fundamental beliefs – sometimes proving so effective that you persuade yourself of the wisdom of an opposing side that you initially dismissed. However, it can be difficult to engage in devil's advocacy with issues of such significance, particularly if you aren't already in the habit of doing so.

Your attempts may end up producing flawed results as you don't feel comfortable undermining the positions that you have gone to such pains to fortify. So, rather than beginning with fraught topics like politics or religion, try to take a contrarian point of view on an issue of far less consequence.

1. Think of a food that you've never enjoyed, especially one that you feel you haven't given enough of a try.
2. Consider the qualities that make it particularly disgusting to you. Is it too sour? Too bitter? Does it have an unusual consistency? Was it the food or preparation that always turned you off? Try to find something that doesn't have an obvious reason to be so repulsive to your palate yet nevertheless manages to gross you out every time.
3. Once you settle on your revolting food of choice, it's time to experiment. Try the food in different locations, prepared by different cooks, with different ingredients – you could even try cooking the food yourself.
4. Keep a record of these experiments to see what it is about the food that you still don't care for. Or, if you have found some way to transform the previously inedible substance into something tasty, make a note of that.
5. After experimenting with food, you might want to try to expand to other areas. Read a book by an author that you've never liked, watch a television show that you've never been interested in, or try playing a game that you've always assumed you'd hate. In every case, you might not change your mind, but you'll undoubtedly broaden your horizons, if only slightly.

Step 2: Feel out fundamental contrarianism.

Although arguments about food or art can become quite heated, most would agree that this contentiousness pales in comparison to the furor that can arise with weightier subjects: poverty, the environment, questions regarding the very fabric of the universe, etc. You may view your opinions on these topics as inseparable from your identity, personally and as a part of some larger cultural, ethnic, political, or religious group.

Yet because these beliefs are so closely tied to who you are, you must learn to question them, seeing past your blind spots to better recognize – and perhaps even empathize with – the opposing beliefs held by your adversaries.

1. Come up with a controversial topic that has an opposing position that you've always rejected out of hand. You'll play devil's advocate

solely within the confines of your head, so there's no need to be afraid to choose a topic that you might feel uncomfortable discussing more publicly.

2. Research the topic as much as you can, reading books and articles, visiting websites, watching documentaries, and so forth, making careful notes of points made by the opposing viewpoint.

3. Do your best to outline an argument that is opposed to your original opinion. Present the most persuasive arguments that the opposing side can muster, but use your own words. If the ideas are still hardly convincing, look for ways that you'd improve the argument or gaps that you felt were ignored.

Step 3: Pick a partner in contrarianism.

Once you've become more accustomed to practicing devil's advocacy on your own, try it with someone else, preferably a trusted friend or loved one. Of course, because you'll be discussing potentially sensitive matters, it's important to find someone with whom you can debate such issues with little risk of hard feelings on either side.

1. Pick a controversial topic, preferably one for which your exercise partner has an opposing viewpoint.

2. Assign yourself and your partner a side of the debate, preferably the *opposite* of your original belief.

3. Do some preliminary research – as in Step 2.

4. Carry out a debate with your partner, with each of you arguing for one side.

5. After the debate, talk it over, returning to your respective views. Did you feel that your partner did well with their side of the debate? How did your debate partner feel about your argument?

You may very well remain unchanged in your opinions about that awful food, that television series, and that controversial topic that you explored and debated. But changing your mind isn't necessarily the point of this exercise. It's about slowing down reactive spontaneity to engage in life's many opportunities with a balance of thoughtful consideration.

Final Words

Sometimes, personal growth is a matter of taking a single action that offers an immediate, gratifying reward – and sometimes, the process is a bit more complicated, with a longer-term payoff. Either way, Entrepreneurs' zest for life means that their path to getting what they want most out of life need never be boring.

As we've seen in these pages, a dose of self-awareness and a dash of planning can help Entrepreneurs go after their long-term aims without giving up on having fun and seizing opportunities in the meantime. For people with this personality type, life is meant to be experienced – and enjoyed. Their personal growth journey may sometimes take them out of their accustomed way of doing things, but it by no means requires them to sacrifice what makes them who they are, including their spontaneous edge and their willingness to break from convention.

Our hope is that this guide gives Entrepreneurs the tools and insights they need to balance their spontaneity and independence with productive habits that will get them where they want to go in the long run. Because for Entrepreneurs, that's what life is all about: achieving their own version of success and fulfillment, all while having fun along the way.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Tools and Assessments.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Entrepreneur Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Entrepreneur Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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